

Blu Foundation | বু ফাউন্ডেশন [NEEDS BENGALI TRANSLATION]

Version: 1.0 DRAFT

Date: June 2026

Applies to: BLU_D05 through BLU_D09 (Class 1–5 Textbooks) and BLU_D10 (Teacher Guide Series)

Companion Documents: BLU_D03_Theory_of_Change.md | BLU_D10_Teacher_Guide_Series.md

1. Purpose of This Framework

This document establishes the pedagogical, cultural, and structural standards that govern all five Blu Foundation class textbooks (Classes 1–5) and the accompanying Teacher Guide Series. Every textbook author, curriculum reviewer, illustrator, and teacher trainer must read and apply this framework before beginning work on any individual class-level document.

The framework exists to ensure:

- Vertical alignment across class levels (concepts introduced in Class 1 are reinforced and extended through Class 5)
- Consistent pedagogical quality across all five textbooks regardless of who produces them
- Cultural appropriateness for the Muslim-majority, South Asian context of Bangladesh
- Age-appropriate content calibrated to the developmental stage of each class level
- Alignment with Bangladesh's National Curriculum and Textbook Board (NCTB) standards and the Directorate of Primary Education (DPE) competency benchmarks

2. Pedagogical Philosophy

Blu Foundation's curriculum is built on a hybrid of two internationally validated frameworks, adapted for the Bangladeshi context:

2.1 Social-Emotional Learning (SEL)

SEL is the process by which children and adults develop the knowledge, skills, and attitudes necessary to understand and manage emotions, achieve positive goals, feel and show empathy, establish and maintain positive relationships, and make responsible decisions [SOURCE_GL_01]. A landmark meta-analysis of 213 SEL programmes covering 270,034 students found that structured SEL produces an average 11-percentile-point improvement in academic achievement alongside significant improvements in social behaviour, reduced conduct problems, and decreased emotional distress [SOURCE_GL_01]. Effects are not short-lived: CASEL's analysis of programmes reaching more than one million students documents positive SEL outcomes lasting up to 18 years [SOURCE_GL_02].

Blu Foundation adopts the CASEL competency framework, adapted for the Bangladesh cultural context, as the organising backbone of all five class textbooks:

CASEL Competency	Blu Foundation Adaptation	Primary Class Level
Self-Awareness	Knowing your own emotions and how they affect behaviour	Class 1–2
Self-Management	Regulating impulses; practising polite habits	Class 1–3
Social Awareness	Understanding others' feelings; respecting diversity	Class 2–4
Relationship Skills	Communication, active listening, conflict resolution	Class 3–5
Responsible Decision-Making	Civic behaviour; community responsibility	Class 4–5

2.2 Character Education

The UK's rigorous multi-school study of character education (10,000 students, 255 teachers, 68 schools) demonstrates that any school type can nurture good character with the right structured approach [SOURCE_UK_01]. The UK Government's Character Education Framework further establishes that schools with explicit character plans — dedicated staff, deliberate activities, and named virtues — produce the widest range of positive outcomes [SOURCE_UK_04]. Blu Foundation embeds this insight structurally: each textbook names its character virtues explicitly, defines them in child-accessible language, and returns to them repeatedly across activities.

The virtues Blu Foundation teaches across the five-class programme are:

Virtue	Bengali [NEEDS BENGALI TRANSLATION]	Introduced	Deepened
Respect	সম্মান	Class 1	All classes
Kindness	দয়া	Class 1	Class 2–3
Honesty	সত্যতা	Class 2	Class 3–4
Patience	ধৈর্য	Class 2	Class 3
Responsibility	দায়িত্ব	Class 3	Class 4–5
Empathy	সহানুভূতি	Class 3	Class 4–5
Civic Pride	নাগরিক গর্ব	Class 5	—

2.3 Islamic Ethical Integration

Bangladesh is a Muslim-majority country where Islamic values are a fundamental reference point for family ethics and social norms. Blu Foundation integrates Islamic ethical teachings as a cultural and spiritual reinforcement of the same character virtues — not as a competing framework, but as a resonant one. References to Quranic principles (e.g., respect for parents as enjoined in Surah Al-Isra), Hadith traditions related to cleanliness and honesty, and the concept of Adab (Islamic etiquette) are woven into relevant units across all class levels.

This integration is handled with care: textbooks are reviewed by a qualified Islamic scholar before publication to ensure all references are accurate, appropriate, and non-sectarian [FOUNDER INPUT REQUIRED: Identify and contract Islamic scholar reviewer before textbook production begins].

3. Age-Appropriate Content Mapping

3.1 Developmental Framework

The content scope and sequence is grounded in established developmental psychology — specifically Erikson's stages of psychosocial development and Piaget's stages of cognitive development — adapted for the Bangladesh primary school context [SOURCE_GL_05].

Class	Typical Age	Developmental Stage	Key Developmental Tasks	Implications for Etiquette Content
1	6–7	Initiative vs. Guilt (Erikson); Pre-operational to Early Concrete (Piaget)	Learning cause-and-effect; developing sense of right and wrong through immediate consequences	Concrete, story-based, immediate and tangible examples; simple rules with clear rationale ("Say please because it makes people feel good")
2	7–8	Industry vs. Inferiority (Erikson); Concrete Operational (Piaget)	Building competence; learning to follow rules; peer relationships becoming important	Procedural etiquette (how to do things correctly); simple social comparisons; "good habits" framing
3	8–9	Industry vs. Inferiority (Erikson); Concrete Operational (Piaget)	Strong sense of fairness; beginning to understand others' perspectives	Role play and perspective-taking; community rules; understanding WHY social norms exist
4	9–10	Industry vs. Inferiority (Erikson); Concrete Operational to Formal Operations (Piaget)	Peer influence significant; abstract reasoning emerging; media awareness	Case studies; digital context; understanding social consequences of behaviour
5	10–11	Identity vs. Role Confusion begins (Erikson); Formal Operations (Piaget)	Self-concept forming; civic identity; future orientation	Leadership framing; community responsibility; introduction to professional norms

3.2 Content Scope and Sequence

The table below maps each textbook's five topic units against the five CASEL competency domains, showing vertical alignment:

Topic Domain	Class 1	Class 2	Class 3	Class 4	Class 5
Verbal etiquette	Please/Thank you	—	Greetings across contexts	Communication styles	Professional language
Physical manners	Listening posture	Dining manners	Public behaviour	Personal space online	Environmental responsibility
Hygiene and self-care	Cleanliness basics	Extended hygiene	—	—	—

Respect for others	Sharing/taking turns	Kindness to family	Respecting elders	Empathy	Cultural tolerance
Public/civic behaviour	—	Home manners	Religious spaces	Cyberbullying	Community leadership

4. Teaching Methodologies by Class Level

Blu Foundation mandates that each class level use the pedagogical methods best matched to the developmental stage of its learners. The methodology assigned to each class is not a preference — it is a specification that authors and teachers must follow [SOURCE_ALT_03].

Class 1 — Story-Based Learning with Songs and Rhymes

Rationale: Ages 6–7 children are in the pre-operational or early concrete operational stage. They learn through narrative, rhythm, and repetition. Research confirms that fairy tales, animal characters, and sung content are among the most effective vehicles for early character education [SOURCE_ALT_03].

Required elements in every Class 1 chapter:

- A short story (200–300 words) featuring the recurring Blu Foundation mascot characters
- A simple song or rhyme related to the chapter's etiquette theme [NEEDS BENGALI TRANSLATION for all songs]
- One illustrated activity (colouring, circle the correct behaviour, match the pairs)
- A sticker or star chart element for self-monitoring

Mascot characters (to be maintained across all Class 1 materials):

- Rafi (রাফি [NEEDS BENGALI TRANSLATION]) — a 6-year-old boy, curious and energetic
- Mitu (মিতু [NEEDS BENGALI TRANSLATION]) — a 6-year-old girl, warm and empathetic
- Dadu (দাদু [NEEDS BENGALI TRANSLATION]) — Rafi's grandfather, wise and kind [FOUNDER INPUT REQUIRED: Confirm mascot names, visual design, and whether to hire character illustrator separately]

Class 2 — Activity-Based Learning

Rationale: Ages 7–8 children are in the concrete operational stage and learn through doing. They respond to structured tasks with clear steps, observable outcomes, and tangible products [SOURCE_GL_05].

Required elements in every Class 2 chapter:

- A short scenario (100–150 words) showing a behaviour problem and its resolution
- At least 2 structured activities: one individual (fill-in, draw, arrange in order), one paired or group
- A "Good Habits Checklist" — a simple daily tracking list for home use [NEEDS BENGALI TRANSLATION]
- A "Parent Corner" box with 2–3 sentences explaining the chapter theme to families

Class 3 — Role Play and Group Activities

Rationale: Ages 8–9 children understand fairness, can take others' perspectives, and benefit from structured social practice. Role play creates a safe context for rehearsing social behaviour [SOURCE_UK_03].

Required elements in every Class 3 chapter:

- A written role play script (4–6 characters, 1–2 pages) that children can perform in class
- A group discussion prompt with 3 guided questions
- A "What would you do?" branching scenario with 2–3 options and consequences
- A personal reflection question for journalling or verbal sharing

Class 4 — Case Studies and Digital Scenarios

Rationale: Ages 9–10 children are developing abstract reasoning and are significantly influenced by peers and media. Case studies based on recognisable scenarios — including digital contexts — make etiquette concepts immediate and relevant [SOURCE_BD_13].

Required elements in every Class 4 chapter:

- A realistic case study (200–250 words) set in a school, home, or digital context
- A "What went wrong?" analysis exercise
- A digital scenario specifically addressing online or phone-based behaviour
- A peer discussion activity: "What would you say to...?"
- A "My Commitment" personal pledge statement

Class 5 — Projects and Community Challenges

Rationale: Ages 10–11 children are forming civic identity and can engage with longer-term, community-facing tasks. Project-based learning at this level connects etiquette values to real-world impact [SOURCE_UK_04].

Required elements in every Class 5 chapter:

- A community challenge or project (week-long, involving family or neighbourhood)
- A leadership reflection: "How can I model this for younger students?"
- A research or interview task connecting to real community issues
- A chapter presentation activity (student presents findings to class)
- An "Etiquette Ambassador" badge/stamp element for chapter completion

5. The SAFE Delivery Model

All Blu Foundation textbooks and teacher guides are designed to conform to the SAFE delivery model — the evidence-based standard for effective SEL programme delivery [SOURCE_GL_03]:

SAFE Component	Definition	Implementation in Blu Foundation Materials
----------------	------------	--

Sequenced	Activities build on each other in a deliberate, connected sequence	Each chapter's 5 units follow a consistent flow: introduce → practise → reflect → apply at home. Across years, concepts build (Class 1 sharing → Class 3 community fairness → Class 5 civic responsibility)
Active	Students are active participants, not passive recipients	Every chapter requires at least one hands-on activity; no chapter is lecture-only; group work is specified at Class 3+
Focused	Dedicated class time is allocated to SEL; it is not embedded invisibly	Textbooks are standalone subjects requiring 2–3 dedicated class periods per week, not embedded in Bengali or religion class
Explicit	Skills and virtues are named, defined, and discussed directly	Each chapter opens by naming the virtue or skill being developed; children are asked to define it in their own words

6. Standard Chapter Template

Every chapter in every Blu Foundation textbook (D05–D09) must follow this exact structure:

```
## Chapter [Number]: [Title]
### The Virtue of This Chapter: [Virtue Name in English and Bengali [NEEDS BENGALI TRANSLATION]]

**Learning Objective:** By the end of this chapter, students will be able to [specific, observable behaviour].

**[Story / Scenario / Case Study / Script]**
[Content appropriate to class level – see Section 4]

**Key Words:**
- [Word 1]: [Simple definition] | [Bengali [NEEDS BENGALI TRANSLATION]]
- [Word 2]: [Simple definition] | [Bengali [NEEDS BENGALI TRANSLATION]]
- [Word 3]: [Simple definition] | [Bengali [NEEDS BENGALI TRANSLATION]]

**Activity [1 or 2, class-level appropriate]:**
[Instructions and worksheet content]

**Think About It (Reflection Question):**
[One open-ended question for verbal or written response]

**Try It At Home (Home Challenge):**
[One specific behaviour to practise at home this week]

---

**Teacher Notes:** [Brief guidance – full lesson plan in BLU_D10]
**Parent Corner:** [2–3 sentences for families – Bengali primary [NEEDS BENGALI TRANSLATION]]
```

7. Illustration and Visual Design Guidelines

7.1 Cultural Representation

All illustrations must:

- Reflect Bangladeshi everyday environments: brick homes, rickshaws, local market scenes, classroom settings with wooden benches, masjid and temple exteriors
- Feature children in standard Bangladeshi school uniform (white shirt/shalwar, blue pants/shalwar kameez) unless scenes are set at home or in the community
- Include characters with South Asian facial features, skin tones ranging from light to dark brown, and black hair — no Eurocentric default appearances
- Represent both urban and rural settings across the five textbooks (at least 40% of scenes should be identifiable as rural or semi-urban)

7.2 Gender Representation

- Female and male characters must appear in roughly equal proportion across each textbook
- Girls must be shown in active, confident, and leadership roles — not solely domestic or passive roles
- All female characters must be depicted in modest clothing consistent with Bangladeshi norms (shalwar kameez, headscarf optional — not universal) [FOUNDER INPUT REQUIRED: Confirm policy on depicting girls with and without headscarf in illustrations]
- Boys must be shown in caring and domestic roles (helping at home, caring for elderly) as well as active/outdoor settings

7.3 Technical Specifications

- All illustrations: vector-based (SVG source files retained)
- Colour palette: warm, accessible colours; avoid red as a dominant tone (associated with danger in children's minds)
- Text in illustrations: Bengali only [NEEDS BENGALI TRANSLATION] — captions in English are in the body text
- Minimum font size in illustrations: 14pt equivalent at final print size [FOUNDER INPUT REQUIRED: Confirm illustrator procurement — in-house vs. commissioned freelancer vs. NGO illustration partner]

8. Assessment Approach

Blu Foundation's assessment model is explicitly non-marks-based. Character and etiquette education cannot and should not be graded as academic performance. Assessment serves observation and improvement — not ranking or sorting.

8.1 Formative Assessment (Ongoing)

Teachers use the observation checklist from BLU_D10 (Teacher Guide Series) to record behavioural indicators during class. Checklist items are drawn from the learning objectives of each chapter and worded as observable behaviours:

Example (Class 2, Chapter 1 — Dining Manners):

- ☐ Student waits for others before beginning to eat
- ☐ Student uses right hand for eating when culturally applicable
- ☐ Student does not waste food on their plate
- ☐ Student says "thank you" to the person who served them

8.2 Summative Assessment (End of Term)

At the end of each school term, the teacher completes a holistic behavioural profile for each student — not a score, but a narrative description across 3–4 domains. This feeds into the M&E framework in BLU_D17.

8.3 Self-Assessment (Student-Facing)

Class 1–3 textbooks include visual self-assessment tools (sticker charts, smiley-face scales, behaviour tracking sheets). Class 4–5 textbooks include written self-reflection journals and pledge statements. These tools encourage metacognition — children thinking about their own thinking and behaviour.

9. Bangladesh NCTB Alignment

Blu Foundation positions its etiquette textbooks as a supplementary resource, not a replacement for any NCTB subject. However, the content maps clearly onto several NCTB primary curriculum competencies, making the case for eventual formal integration.

NCTB Subject	Relevant NCTB Competency	Blu Foundation Contribution
Bangladesh and Global Studies	Social values and citizenship	Deepens civic and community content beyond factual knowledge
Religion and Moral Education	Moral conduct and character	Operationalises character virtues into daily behavioural practice
Bengali Language	Communication skills	Extends to interpersonal communication and listening etiquette
Physical Education and Health	Personal hygiene and self-care	Adds social and public hygiene dimensions

Blu Foundation will submit a formal curriculum alignment proposal to NCTB in Year 3 of the strategic plan, positioning this framework as the evidence base for integration.

10. Gender Inclusion Standards

Blu Foundation is committed to gender inclusion in all curriculum content. The following standards are mandatory across all five textbooks [SOURCE_BD_17][SOURCE_ALT_06]:

- 1. **Gender-neutral scenarios:** Where possible, scenarios do not assume a gendered participant. Role play scripts assign roles before children read them — no character is "the girl who cooks" or "the boy who leads" by default.
- 2. **Affirmative representation of girls:** At least 50% of all protagonist roles in stories and scenarios are female characters. Girls are shown initiating respectful behaviour, resolving conflicts, and taking leadership — not only receiving kindness.
- 3. **Challenging harmful norms:** Class 4 and 5 content explicitly addresses the importance of respecting women and girls in public spaces, without naming specific harmful practices in ways that are inappropriate for the age group. The framing is positive ("how we treat everyone with respect in public") rather than problem-cataloguing.
- 4. **Teacher training reinforcement:** The Teacher Guide (BLU_D10) includes a dedicated section on gender-equitable facilitation — how teachers can moderate discussions without reinforcing harmful gender norms.

11. Islamic Cultural Sensitivity Guidelines

All content across the five textbooks must meet the following Islamic cultural sensitivity standards, reviewed by Blu Foundation's Islamic scholar advisory council member [FOUNDER INPUT REQUIRED: Appoint Islamic scholar reviewer]:

- 1. **Islamic etiquette references:** Where Islamic greetings (Assalamu Alaikum), practices (eating with the right hand, removing shoes in mosques), and values (cleanliness as half of faith — Hadith reference) are included, they must be accurately quoted and sourced.
- 2. **Inclusive framing:** Blu Foundation serves students across all religious backgrounds in Bangladesh. Islamic references are framed as "our tradition" or "in Islamic teaching" — not as universal or exclusive mandates. Non-Muslim characters in scenarios are portrayed with equivalent respect and dignity.
- 3. **Prohibited content:** No content should depict: pork or alcohol in any context; disrespectful treatment of religious figures; mixed-gender physical contact between unrelated characters aged 10+; or images of faces in prayer positions (to avoid artistic representation concerns in some interpretations).
- 4. **Quranic and Hadith citations:** Any direct quotation from the Quran or Hadith must be verified by the Islamic scholar reviewer before inclusion. Paraphrase is preferable to direct quotation to avoid translation disputes.

12. Pre-Publication Review Process

Every textbook must pass through the following review gates before printing:

Review Gate	Reviewer	Focus	Required Before
Curriculum review	Curriculum Lead + external education researcher (BRAC/IED)	Pedagogical accuracy, age-appropriateness, NCTB alignment	Gate 2
Cultural sensitivity review	Islamic scholar advisory council member	Islamic content accuracy, cultural appropriateness	Gate 3

Gender review	Gender specialist (external)	Representation equity, harmful norm avoidance	Gate 3
Language review	Bengali language specialist	Translation accuracy, reading level appropriateness	Gate 4
Student user testing	10 students per class level from a non-pilot school	Comprehension, engagement, clarity	Gate 4
Final approval	Executive Director	Overall quality, organisational voice	Print sign-off

[FOUNDER INPUT REQUIRED: Identify reviewers for each gate before production begins — particularly the BRAC/IED education researcher and the gender specialist]

Appendix A — Source Summary

Citation Key	Relevance to This Framework
[SOURCE_GL_01]	SEL meta-analysis establishing 11-percentile academic gain; basis for SEL as core pedagogy
[SOURCE_GL_02]	CASEL research confirming 18-year lasting effects; justifies long-term investment in primary-level SEL
[SOURCE_GL_03]	SAFE delivery model — the structural standard all Blu Foundation materials conform to
[SOURCE_GL_05]	SEL effects at elementary level; developmental appropriateness evidence
[SOURCE_UK_01]	UK character education study: any school type achieves results with structured approach
[SOURCE_UK_03]	UK Character Education Framework: schools with explicit plans use widest range of activities
[SOURCE_UK_04]	UK guidance on how character plans should be documented and implemented
[SOURCE_ALT_03]	Evidence base for fairy tales, songs, and animal characters as effective vehicles for early character education
[SOURCE_ALT_06]	Gender attitudes among Bangladeshi adolescents — informs gender inclusion standards
[SOURCE_BD_03]	Early childhood as optimal character formation period; basis for Class 1 design
[SOURCE_BD_13]	Social media influence on Bangladeshi student behaviour — basis for Class 4 digital content
[SOURCE_BD_17]	Gender and language in Bangladesh — informs gender inclusion standards

BLU_D04 — Textbook Master Framework | Blu Foundation | Version 1.0 DRAFT | June 2026
All textbook authors must read and sign this framework before beginning class-level content development.